

Dr Jambulingam kneels by a damaged torso of the Buddha found in January 2015 in a field of sugarcane in the village of Manalur, near Thanjavur.

Most of these stone and bronze Buddhas can be dated to between the ninth and twelfth centuries, when the Imperial Cholas were at the height of their power. This is long after Buddhism in Tamil country is supposed to have become extinct. They show not only that pockets of Buddhism survived but that it was tolerated by the Cholas, the most ardent devotees of Lord Shiva.